

COHORT BRIEFING · HIRING PARTNER PROJECTS

Your Guide to **Standing Out.**

What hiring partners actually look for — and how to deliver it.

FOR THE COHORT · INTERNAL BRIEFING

• READ TIME · 8 MINUTES

1

project. One of the highest-leverage things you'll do in the entire cohort.

Not a coding exercise. A window into who you are.

Hiring partner projects are your chance to demonstrate real-world skills, show your professionalism, and make a lasting impression on a potential employer.

It is the clearest single signal a partner will get about you as a developer — and as a collaborator.

Share **early** and often.
The cohort is your **greatest resource** —
don't wait until you're done.

01

Talk through your approach

Before you build. Pressure-test the plan with peers.

02

Trade honest feedback

Specific, direct, kind. What makes it feel polished?

03

Ask Derek & Jon

They've seen what lands and what falls flat.

04

Mock interview first

The first walkthrough should never be with the partner.

Six things great projects always **do.**

01 Complete the ask

Read the brief twice. Ship every deliverable.

02 Usable & deployed

Live URL. Clickable right now.

03 Adds real value

Solve a problem. Sweat the details.

04 Knows their business

Their colors, fonts, language, products.

05 Ready to present

Defend every major decision out loud.

06 Carries your style

Taste, voice, intent — unmistakably yours.

01_{/06}

PRINCIPLE ONE

Incomplete submissions signal poor attention to detail. Don't give them that read.

Complete the **ask**.

- Read the requirements more than once before you start building.
- Check off every deliverable before submitting.
- When in doubt, ask a clarifying question early — not at the deadline.

02_{/06}

PRINCIPLE TWO

If it only runs on your machine, it isn't done.

Usable & deployed.

- Deploy to Vercel, Netlify, Railway, or similar — clickable now.
- Test it in a browser you didn't develop in. Things break in unexpected places.
- Include a clean README with setup instructions if local run matters.

03 / 06

PRINCIPLE THREE

The best projects don't just check boxes — they solve something real.

Add real **value**.

- Think about the end user's experience — not just the technical implementation.
- Small extras matter: loading states, error handling, accessibility.
- If you have time, add one thoughtful feature that wasn't asked for — and explain why.

04 / 06

PRINCIPLE FOUR

This is where most candidates fall short — and where you can stand out immediately.

Show you know their business.

- Use their color scheme — pull hex codes from their site or brand guidelines.
- Match their font styles — check Google Fonts or their CSS for what they use.
- Reference their actual products, services, and language where appropriate.
- Spend 30 minutes on their site, LinkedIn, and press before writing a line of code.

05 / 06

Come prepared with talking points.

- Walk through your architecture, tech choices, and data flow on demand.
- Frame the project in terms of the value it delivers to them specifically.
- Be ready for "why did you build it this way?" on every major decision.
- Practice your presentation out loud — once to yourself, once with a peer.

PRINCIPLE FIVE

Building is half the work.
Defending it is the other half.

06 / 06

Put your style **into it.**

- Don't copy a tutorial structure — make intentional design decisions and own them.
- Think about what makes your solution uniquely yours.
- Write code you're proud to show — clean, readable, intentional.

PRINCIPLE SIX

You are not just submitting code.
You are submitting yourself.

Research. Plan. Build.

01 Read the brief, twice. Highlight every deliverable. Underline anything ambiguous.	02 Research the partner. Website, LinkedIn, product, recent press.	03 Note their language. Colors, fonts, industry-specific terms, tone of voice.	04 Wireframe the approach. Outline architecture and screens before you write code.	05 Build the core. Get it working end-to-end. Function before polish.
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Polish. Deploy. Present.

06 Refine the UI. Match the partner's brand — colors, type, voice.	07 Add personal touches. The extras that prove you care about craft.	08 Deploy & test live. Open the live URL in a fresh browser. Click everything.	09 Write README & notes. Setup steps. Architecture. Why each major choice.	10 Rehearse, twice. Once solo. Once with a peer. Out loud — every time.
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CLOSING

Don't just submit. Stand out.

Six principles. Ten steps. Every project is a chance to show a hiring partner exactly who you are.

01 Complete the ask

02 Usable & deployed

03 Adds value

04 Knows the business

05 Ready to present

06 Your style